FOR PASTORS, CHURCH MEMBERS, AND THE BELIEVER ON A SCHOOL BOARD · READ ALOUD IN UNDER THREE MINUTES

A page to read aloud

I was a minister. I have spent fifteen years on the question of whether a school should paddle a child, and I want to give you the whole of what I have learned in the time it takes to read this page.

The Bible speaks of the rod. It says a father who loves his son corrects him. I am not here to tell you those verses mean something else. I am here to tell you what the same Bible says about how to judge any correction.

It says: "Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness." Judge the chastening by its fruit, afterward, in the child.

It says: "Ye shall know them by their fruits."

It says: "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good."

So we looked at the fruit. Researchers followed tens of thousands of children, in seventy-five studies, and compared the ones who were hit with the ones who were not. Of seventeen things they measured, thirteen were worse for the children who were hit. Not one was better. In the schools, the children who were paddled did worse in class, not better. They grew up with more depression, and Paul wrote, "Provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged." They grew up more likely to paddle their own children, and Paul wrote, "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap."

No study has ever found that stopping made a school worse. Fifty-four controlled studies have found that teaching children how to behave, and practicing it with them, makes a school better.

That is the fruit. By scripture's own test, the paddle fails.

Every rod verse in Proverbs is addressed to a parent about that parent's own child. Not one is addressed to a school. The question before a school board is whether an employee of the district may strike someone else's child with a board. Proverbs does not answer that. The fruit does.

The Presbyterians voted on this and said no. The Methodists said no. More than eleven hundred school boards in the states that still allow it have said no, in one sentence: the Board prohibits the use of corporal punishment in the District.

Discipline means teaching. A disciple is a learner. Let us teach them.

The whole guide, with every verse and every source, is at earthpilot.org/kids/kit/a-christians-guide/

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